

Rep. Tom Emmer on Fox News Live

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AYESHA:

Let's bring in House Majority Whip and Minnesota Congressman Tom Emmer. Congressman Whip, thank you very much for joining me on your Easter weekend. I want to get to this developing news here as this urgent search continues for our service member. Do you think at this moment, are you worried that this changes our timeline when it comes to Iran?

REP. TOM EMMER:

No, I don't worry about it. I think our president, as you know, Ayesha, he didn't start this war. He's finishing it. And as he told the American public a couple of nights ago, they're well on their way to being done. In fact, what they have done is historic, hit over 11,000 targets. The drone activity is down by 90 percent. It has effectively destroyed the Iranian infrastructure in just a matter of weeks, and now it's the end of the process. Obviously, our prayers go out to the air crewmen that we are looking for right now. But when the president says this is not going to affect negotiations, I agree.

AYESHA:

OK. I want to move on to this DHS funding fight that you guys are right in the thick of it right now. And it looks like the speaker has lined up with Senate Majority Leader John Thune. Are you guys going to try to do this something through pro forma this week? Is that on the table?

REP. TOM EMMER:

No, not as far as I know, unless something changes. Frankly, what has happened here is the Senate. It was a bad look. You don't pass something at three in the morning with only six people on the floor and literally defund everything, fund everything but the Immigration and Customs Enforcement and Border Patrol. It just doesn't work that way. It's a bad precedent for the House. The House, frankly, with our speaker, has negotiated that the Senate will move this as quick as they can when they get back to town after the Easter recess. And the White House has assured us that the relevant agencies have the money they need to do the job that they're required to do over this period of time. So no, I do not expect something to happen in the coming week except for discussions on how quickly this moves and what it looks like when we get back after the Easter holiday.

AYESHA:

But don't you want to get these people paid? There will still be people that are not getting paid. Don't you feel like it's important to get this done as quickly as possible instead of waiting for this break to be over?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Ayesha, the House has done this. We passed complete funding four times. By the way, a bill that was agreed to on a bicameral, bipartisan basis, Republicans and Democrats, it's just because of extreme anarchist, Marxist,

socialist base that Chuck Schumer has to deal with that he reneged on the deal. Yes, Republicans have been trying to do this since the beginning of the year. The problem we've got is the precedent that has been set is not going to be good going forward. If you're going to be able to pull out whatever piece you don't like in an appropriations bill, where does this end, Ayesha? The next time we have an agricultural appropriations bill, somebody's going to want to pull out something they don't like from that. So it's a big deal in the House. We've been trying to get this done. God bless our president for making sure that our TSA agents are paid. I'm told by Secretary Mark Wayne Mullen that he's got the money that he needs to make sure these people are getting paid until we get back. And then it's really important that we get this thing done once and for all before the end of April.

AYESHA:

So I know there's quite a contingent of Republicans that want to see this paired up with reconciliation. They want enough progress made on reconciliation in getting this money funded into ICE before they vote on this particular bill to fund DHS. But we know that reconciliation can take a long time, Whip. You know that. Last year, I believe it officially started in February, didn't wrap up until July. So make the case to federal workers out there who are already frustrated that this is going on and has lasted this long. It started, I think, on Valentine's Day. How can you promise them that reconciliation will be wrapped up quickly?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, this is the commitment that the Speaker got from the Senate, because you're right. And the delay typically comes on the Senate side. They have to take a lot longer than the House does, even though we have a process in the House. There are two schools of thought right now, Arshad. The first one is that Lindsey Graham over on the Senate side waives the hearing process, moves a budget resolution immediately. He can get that done very quickly. And then the Senate would originate a skinny reconciliation bill that would only fund CBP and ICE. On the House side, there's also another school of thought where you would move the entire Homeland Security funding bill that's already drafted. I mean, that's one of the reasons it takes a while. This stuff is already drafted. As I said to you earlier, we've already passed it at least four times. There's a school of thought in the House that you could do the entire Homeland Security bill through a reconciliation process that would originate in the House. That's the discussion that I expect to be fleshed out over the next five, six days. And then we have to get this done immediately in April, which is what the commitment again is the Speaker got from the Senate.

AYESHA:

But in the meantime, OK, April, in the meantime, aren't you guys just raiding the big, beautiful bill by forcing the president to take these executive actions to pay these federal workers?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, Republicans are doing what is necessary to make sure that the American public comes first, the safety and security of Americans here at home. Republicans have been doing this from the get-go. It is the Democrats that are trying to stop this for some ridiculous reason. It's about politics for Democrats. It's not about Americans. So Republicans will continue to make sure that these things are funded so that we can do the job of securing the homeland and protecting Americans first and foremost, the security at home. Regardless of where that money comes from, it has to be done and Republicans will make sure that it gets done. And ultimately, we've got to make sure these agencies are funded for the long term, because if we allow this to continue, these radical Democrats are literally going to undermine this process every single time. This is not just about today, Aisha. This is about the future.

AYESHA:

Well, if you allow it to continue, you may not have the House in November with Emmer. That's I'm sure on your mind as well. So we will look forward to seeing what happens in the House and the Senate as you guys work to fund DHS with Emmer. Thank you so much for joining me. Happy Easter.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Happy Easter to you, Aisha. Thank you.

This transcript was independently produced by MN-06 Watch for accountability and archival purposes.

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